

Phishing Email Detection & Awareness System

Document Title: How to Spot and Stop Fake Emails: A Simple Guide for Everyone

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Target Audience: All Company Employees (Non-Technical & Technical)

Date: June 2026

1. What is Phishing? (In Simple Words)

Imagine a fisherman putting bait on a hook to catch a fish. **Phishing** is exactly the same, but it happens over email.

Cybercriminals (hackers) send fake emails that look exactly like they are from your bank, your company's IT team, or a popular service (like Google or Netflix). Their goal is to trick you into:

- Typing your password on a fake page.
- Clicking a dangerous link that infects your computer.
- Sending them sensitive company data.

 **Remember:** Hackers don't always attack our computer systems; they attack **human psychology** because it is easier to trick a person than to break a firewall.

The Fake Email Scenario:

Subject: Urgent: Your Account Will Be Locked

From: Corporate Security Team <security-update@random-domain.com>

Dear User,

We noticed suspicious activity on your account. To avoid account suspension, please verify your details immediately.

Verify Now:

<http://secure-account-verify.com>

Failure to verify within 24 hours will result in permanent account lock.

Regards,

Security Team

3. How to Spot the Red Flags (The 4 Warning Signs)

You don't need to be an IT expert to catch a scam. Just look for these **4 Red Flags** in any email:

Red Flag 1: The "Panic" Button (Urgency)

- **What the hacker did:** They said your account will be locked in *24 hours*.
- **Why they do it:** When people are scared or in a hurry, they stop thinking clearly. Hackers want you to act fast before you have time to double-check.
- **Easy Rule:** If an email threatens you or forces you to act "**Immediately**," it is almost always a scam.

Red Flag 2: "Dear User" (Generic Greeting)

- **What the hacker did:** They addressed you as "Dear User" or "Dear Employee."
- **Why they do it:** Hackers send millions of these emails at once. They don't know your actual name.
- **Easy Rule:** Real emails from your company or your bank will almost always address you by your **real first and last name**.

Red Flag 3: The Fake Sender Address

- **What the hacker did:** The name says "Corporate Security Team," but the actual email address behind it is `security-update@random-domain.com`.
- **Why they do it:** They can type any name they want in the "Display Name," but changing the real domain name to match our official company domain is much harder.
- **Easy Rule:** Always click or hover your mouse over the sender's name to see the *real* email address. If the part after the @ symbol looks strange, delete it.

Red Flag 4: The Tricky Link

- **What the hacker did:** They gave a link:
`[http://secure-account-verify.com](http://secure-account-verify.com)`.
- **Why they do it:** This link leads to a fake login page that looks identical to our company login portal. If you type your password there, the hacker steals it instantly.
- **Easy Rule:** Before clicking any link, **hover your mouse cursor over the link** (without clicking). A small box will pop up showing you the *true destination*. If it doesn't match our official website, do not click! Also, look for `https://` (the "s" stands for Secure). The fake link only has `http://` (Not Secure).

How a Phishing Attack Works (The Simple Step-by-Step Process)

Think of a phishing attack like a **digital trap**. Attackers do not break into our computers using complex hacking codes; instead, they trick **us** into opening the door for them.

Here is exactly how this attack happens in real life:

♦ Step 1: The Attacker Sets the Bait (Creation)

The hacker creates an email that looks exactly like a real message from a trusted source—such as our Company's IT Support, HR Team, a Bank, or Microsoft. They also create a fake website login page that looks identical to our actual company login portal.

♦ Step 2: Creating Artificial Panic (The Trick)

The hacker writes an urgent message. They might say: *"Your account will be permanently deleted in 24 hours"* or *"Suspicious login detected, verify your password now."* They use fear because they know when people are scared, they act fast and forget to check for warning signs.

♦ Step 3: The Employee Clicks the Link (The Trap is Sprung)

The employee sees the urgent email, gets worried, and clicks the **"Verify Now"** button. The link takes them away from the safe company network and lands them directly onto the hacker's fake website.

♦ Step 4: Stealing the Information (The Theft)

On the fake website, the employee is asked to type their username, password, or One-Time Password (OTP) to "unlock" their account. The moment the employee clicks "Submit," their secret password is not sent to the company—it is sent directly to the hacker's screen.

♦ Step 5: Exploiting the Access (The Damage)

Now that the hacker has the real password, they can log into the actual company network. They can steal private company data, read confidential emails, or lock the company's computers to demand money (Ransomware).

4.Quick Summary for Quick Reference :

What to look at	Safe emails	Dangerous Phishing e mail
The Greeting	"Dear John Doe" (Your actual name)	"Dear User" / "Dear Customer" / No name
The Tone	Calm, professional, informative	Creates fear, panic, and gives an ultimatum
The Link	Points to our official website (with https://)	Points to a strange website address (with http://)
The Action	Asks you to follow standard procedures	Asks you to "Verify Passwords" or "Click Here Immediately"

5. The Golden Rules: Do's and Don'ts

✓ DO:

- **DO** slow down. Take 10 seconds to read the email carefully.
- **DO** contact the person or department through a separate channel (e.g., call them or open a fresh browser tab) if you want to verify the email's claims.
- **DO** use the "**Report Phishing**" button in your inbox if something feels wrong.

✗ DON'T:

- **DON'T** click on any buttons or links inside an unexpected email.
- **DON'T** download or open attachments (like Word, Excel, or PDF files) if you weren't expecting them.
- **DON'T** ever type your password, OTP, or credit card details on a page that arrived via an email link.

6. What should you do if you clicked a link?

If you realize you made a mistake and clicked a bad link or entered your password:

1. **Disconnect** your device from the Wi-Fi/Internet immediately.
2. **Contact the IT/Security Team** right away. Do not feel ashamed—reporting it quickly protects the whole company!